

STORMBRINGER — THE STORM PACT

Stormbringer 1st Ed (Oriflam 1984 / BRP) · Mael's Ford, Eastern Marches, Young Kingdoms · 4–6 players · 3 hours

A dying sorcerer. A half-manifested demon. Three options with no clean answer. The world is worse at arrangements than it pretends.

GM TRUTH

Six months ago the sorcerer Kelen — reclusive, brilliant, dying of the wasting sickness — rode to the ancient Melnibonéan ruin on the Eastern Moors to summon Vorak, a Vitalic Demon of Chaos whose power arrests biological decay. He intended to trade an anchor in the world for the years illness had stolen. The ritual failed: a borrowed goat (Tally's — borrowed without asking) broke the containment circle at the critical moment. Vorak is now half-manifested, anchored between worlds, unable to advance or retreat. The pressure outward is the unnatural storms destroying Mael's Ford's harvest. Kelen is still inside the Spire of Kyelm, racing his own death to complete a second binding. He is not a villain. He is a frightened dying man who tried a practical arrangement. The demon is not malicious. It is what it is. Both were making a reasonable deal. The goat is to blame.

■ INTRODUCTION — MAEL'S FORD (~15 min)

Locations: Village Hall — Elder Thara

Thara plants both hands on the table and looks at each player in turn: Kelen disappeared six weeks ago, storms have wrecked the harvest, two cattle struck by lightning, the mill wheel stopped. She does not sit. Payment: 10 gold per person on resolution. Handout SP-H00 (village notice) is already pinned to the door. What Thara will not say: she knew Kelen was ill; she sent her nephew Farren to check on him 20 days ago; Farren came back 'confused' and two days later walked back toward the moors. She has told no one. Insight 40%: she knows more than she is saying — not deception, a village elder protecting her authority while privately terrified.

Clues / handouts: SP-H00 (Village Notice — pinned before play begins)

Pacing: Hard timing: inside the Spire by 1:45. Moral choice locked by 2:45. Compress the moor crossing if needed.

■ ACT ONE — MAEL'S FORD (~30 min)

Locations: Village Square · Blacksmith's Forge · Mira's Herb Garden · Old Harrek's Corner (tavern) · Treeline

Village Square: the cattle pen near the east gate is patched with fresh timber — something broke through from inside, not outside (Spot 30%). Tally (16, unstoppable, currently standing on the well) will not get down until someone agrees to hear about her goat. She is correct about everything. She knows a shortcut via the shepherd's path that cuts 20 minutes off the moor crossing — will only share it if allowed to come or Persuade 50%. Joran (forge): last saw Kelen loading rope, ritual reagents, and a caged goat onto a cart six weeks ago. Went northeast. Insight 40%: Joran believes Kelen is already dead and will not say so in front of anyone who might repeat it. [Essential Clue 1] Mira (herb garden): three nights before the storms she saw blue-white lights from the direction of 'the old tower nobody names' — not firelight, not lightning, from the ground up. Lore(Young Kingdoms) 30%: matches summoning circle opening in historical records. [Essential Clue 2] Old Harrek (tavern corner): Chaos cult trail-marks on trees twice in the past month. Their leader is Dael — formerly a Law novice. Tally: her brother Sevel returned from the moors 'like himself but from far away' then walked back again — Vorak's influence predating storms. [Essential Clue 3] ENCOUNTER — Three Chaos-Touched Wolves: lightning-vein fur, flat silver eyes, POW-bitten investigators get a flash-image of the Spire from above. When two are killed the third breaks — toward the Spire, not away from it. Spot: it is not running. It is going home.

Clues / handouts: Kelen's direction (Joran) [E1] · Blue-white lights (Mira) [E2] · Sevel's voluntary return (Tally) [E3]

Pacing: If over 5 minutes at the 0:45 mark: cut Harrek, move Sevel's information to a line Tally delivers as they leave. Wolf fight max 10 min.

■ ACT TWO — THE MOORS AND THE SPIRE OF KYELM (~90 min)

Locations: Moor Crossing · Gate Arch · Binding Hall (Ground Floor) · Warden's Chamber (2nd Floor) · Finding Kelen (3rd Floor entrance)

Moor Crossing: ozone and deep stone-cold smell, stronger every half-mile. Grass grows in radial patterns centred on the Spire — radius approximately one mile (Navigate/Spot 35%). No animals. No sounds. Gate Arch: Melnibonéan containment wards worn away from INSIDE — something pushing outward for weeks. Chaos cult symbol scratched at knee height, days old. [Essential Clue 4] Binding Hall: 4m geometric binding circle burned into the floor — broken at the eastern arc, near a gouge from a panicking hooved animal. Blood and goat remnants. SP-H01 (working notes fragment) under a loose stone. SP-H02 (binding circle diagram) for players. Lore 40%: the circle shows genuine sophistication. The disruption was circumstance, not incompetence. [Essential Clue 5] ENCOUNTER — The Bound Fragment: a knot of Vorak's Chaos energy guarding the circle. Not Vorak itself. Attacks with Chaos-lash (1D6, ignores armour). Physical strike: POW vs 14 or temporary cosmetic Chaos manifestation — translucent skin, faint blue veins. Sarath recognises it immediately: 'Don't kill it — it's a piece of the binding that got loose. Destroying it may break the last wards.' He is correct. Warden's Chamber: Kelen has been living here six weeks — straw, candles, working notes. SP-H03 (confession letter) found here — hand separately. Finding Kelen: voice from above as players approach the Summoning Spire stairway: 'If you're from Mael's Ford, you're too late to stop me.' He opens the door regardless. He needs witnesses. He explains without prompting — full truth, no games, no time for deception.

Clues / handouts: SP-H01 (working notes) · SP-H02 (binding circle diagram) · SP-H03 (confession letter, hand separately) · Sevel's cloak fragment (Cray, Spot 40%)

Pacing: Cray's player: the cloak fragment is a private moment. Tell them quietly. Give them a beat before continuing.

■ ACT THREE — THE SUMMONING SPIRE (~30 min)

Locations: Summoning Spire, 3rd Floor

Vorak's arrival: not dramatic. A presence condenses in the room — warm where it should be cold, large where there should be space. It does not attack. The half-binding is resolved in the next few minutes or it resolves itself. POW vs 18: failure means 1 round paralysis and -1 permanent POW from proximity. This is not combat. This is awe. THREE OPTIONS — present all with equal weight. Do not telegraph a preference. Option 1 — Kelen's Self-Binding (The Sacrifice): Kelen binds Vorak to himself. Storms stop. He lives perhaps two more years — but changing. Requires 5 minutes of ritual while party holds the space. If the cult arrives, they fight. Leaves a Chaos-bound sorcerer loose in the Young Kingdoms. Option 2 — Object Binding (The Tainted Bargain): demon bound into a weapon or vessel; costs 1D4 permanent POW from the binder. Sarath has the binding scroll (costs the scroll + 1D4 POW). Ysolde can do it from knowledge (same cost). Lian can channel Law (1D6 POW, and the Church will have opinions about a Law devotee binding a Chaos demon). Carrier gets strange dreams and occasional clarity that comes from somewhere else. Forever. Option 3 — Abdication: do nothing or fail to agree. Storms stop — Vorak no longer needs the pressure. Land-drain begins slowly. Mael's Ford empties over a decade. Nothing catastrophic tonight. Combined binding (Options 1+2): mechanically possible if two performers roll simultaneously vs POW 18. Vorak doubly constrained. Kelen's progression slows. This is the best outcome and costs the most POW. Let the table find it if they look.

Pacing: At 2:45 hard stop: if unresolved, the light becomes too bright to look at directly. Force the choice.

■ EPILOGUE (~15 min)

Locations: Mael's Ford and beyond

Option 1: storms stop that night. Kelen leaves the Spire and disappears into the Young Kingdoms. Three months later: reports from a village two days east of a gaunt old man following deer herds on the moors. He is keeping them alive through winter. The deer do not run from him. Option 2: storms stop within the hour. Kelen sits down — dying here now, slowly, without urgency. First dream comes three days later: 47 deer surviving a winter they should not survive. The knowledge is accurate. It does not stop. Option 3: village celebrates. In three years a healer from Karlaak notes unusual vitality depletion in the population and recommends relocation.

Pacing: Kelen is not a villain to be dealt with. What happens to him is a function of what the players chose and how they treated him.

KEY NPCS

Elder Thara *Village elder, late 60s*

STR 9 CON 12 INT 14 POW 15 · HP 11 · Influence 70%, Insight 60%, Persuade 55%
Direct, composed, protective of authority. Will answer honestly when trusted. Knows about Farren — won't offer it unprompted.

Joran Blacksmith, *mid-40s*

STR 16 CON 14 INT 10 POW 11 · HP 14 · Craft(Smith) 75%, Brawl 60%

Measured, practical. Thinks Kelen is dead. Insight 40% reveals this. Personal grudge: Kelen still has his best chisel.

Mira Herbalist, *early 20s*

STR 8 CON 11 INT 15 POW 13 · HP 10 · Lore(Herbs) 70%, Spot 55%

Guarded (dismissed by Thara already). Opens when taken seriously. Don't qualify what she saw.

Old Harrek *Former adventurer, late 70s*

STR 11 CON 13 INT 16 POW 14 · HP 13 · Lore(Young Kingdoms) 75%, Insight 65%
Will not go near the Spire — considered decision, not cowardice. Buy the drink, ask without urgency.

PLAYER CHARACTERS & HANDOUTS

Davin Kell *Ilmioran Mercenary — Broadsword 65%, Shield 55%*

STR 15 CON 14 HP 14 DB +1D4

Escorted Kelen's supplies 6 months ago. Still owed 4 silver. Here partly out of mercenary interest.

Ysolde of Vilmir *Scholar-Sorcerer — Lore(Melnibonéan) 65%, Summon Demon 45%*

INT 16 POW 16 HP 11

Has researched the Spire for 3 years. This is professional fieldwork. Will spend the session collecting evidence.

Cray *Cutpurse from Nadsokor — Stealth 70%, Fast Talk 65%*

DEX 17 HP 11

Knew Tally's brother Sevel. Not here for the money. Will not say this unless directly asked.

SP-H00 — Village Notice — 'Reward offered. Speak to Elder Thara.' (pinned to hall door before play)

SP-H01 — Kelen's Working Notes (fragment) — found in Binding Hall; formulae; '...if the circle does not hold—' [page torn]

KEY ROLLS: Insight 40% (Thara hides more / Joran thinks Kelen dead) · Lore(Melnibonéan) 40% (ward glyphs worn from inside) · Lore(Chaos/Melnibonéan) 40% (circle sophistication; disruption point) · Spot 40% (Cray — Sevel's cloak) · Summon Demon vs Vorak POW 18 (binding roll) · POW vs 18 (Vorak proximity — paralysis + -1 POW on fail)

Tally *Village teenager, 16 — Bran the goat's owner*

STR 8 CON 10 INT 13 POW 12 DEX 15 · HP 10 · Fast Talk 65%, Navigate 60%
Unstoppable. Knows the shepherd's shortcut. Knows about Sevel (brother, not offered unless trusted). SHOULD NOT enter the Spire.

Kelen *Dying sorcerer, early 60s*

STR 9 CON 8 INT 16 POW 17 · HP 10 (illness) · Summon Demon 75%, Lore(Chaos) 65%, Lore(Melnibonéan) 60%

Past desperation — calm on the other side of it. Tells the truth without prompting. Will not stop the binding attempt even if asked.

Vorak *Vitalic Demon of Chaos*

STR 22 CON 20 SIZ 18 INT 14 POW 18 · HP 19 · Chaos-lash 60%, 1D10, ignores non-magical armour

Not hostile. Responds to intent, not language. Approaching with a binding = permission. Approaching with a weapon = combat. Cannot be permanently killed here.

Dael (optional) *Chaos cult leader — former Law devotee*

Only deploy if time is ample. A mirror of Lian — what she could become.

Arrives at the Spire during Act 3 to prevent any binding. Use only if pace is fast.

Sarath the Twice-Turned *Ex-Pan Tang cultist — Lore(Chaos) 70%, Summon Demon 50%*

POW 15 HP 12

Has seen a failed binding before. Carries binding scroll (1 use, costs 1D4 permanent POW). Does not want to use it.

Captain Brenn *Tarkeshite sailor — Cutlass 60%, Navigate 65%*

STR 13 CON 15 HP 14 DB +1D4

Here for coin. Has already decided this is not manageable. Stays because he does not walk out on work.

Lian *Devotee of Law — Insight 65%, Healing 55%*

INT 14 POW 14 HP 11

First real field assignment. Prepared extensively. The moral dilemma in Act 3 hits this character hardest of all.

SP-H02 — Binding Circle Diagram — 4m geometric pattern; eastern arc broken; gouge mark; dark stain at break

SP-H03 — Kelen's Confession Letter — full account; 'The demon is not evil. I am not evil. The world is worse at arrangements than it pretends.' (hand separately)